

What Nepal Buys From India, by the Numbers

Twenty major commodities, five accounting periods, and one bar that dwarfs every other. A walk through the statistics of Nepal's southern import bill — its skew, its outlier, its surprising calm at the core.

OPENING BALANCES • Rs. IN MILLION

Major-commodity import bill, 2024/25 annual	≈ 1,052,752
Largest single line item (Petroleum, 2023/24)	300,651
Median commodity, 2025/26 six months	19,959
Statistical outliers detected (IQR & z-score)	1
Fastest-growing import (Silver, six-month)	+362%
Steepest decline (Edible Oil, six-month)	-38%

ENTRY 1

One Commodity to Rule the Ledger

Line up Nepal's twenty biggest imports from India and the chart barely needs a caption. Petroleum products came in at Rs. 300,651 million in 2023/24 — nearly **four times** the second-largest entry, machinery parts at Rs. 78,852 million. Fuel is not merely the top import; it is a different order of magnitude.

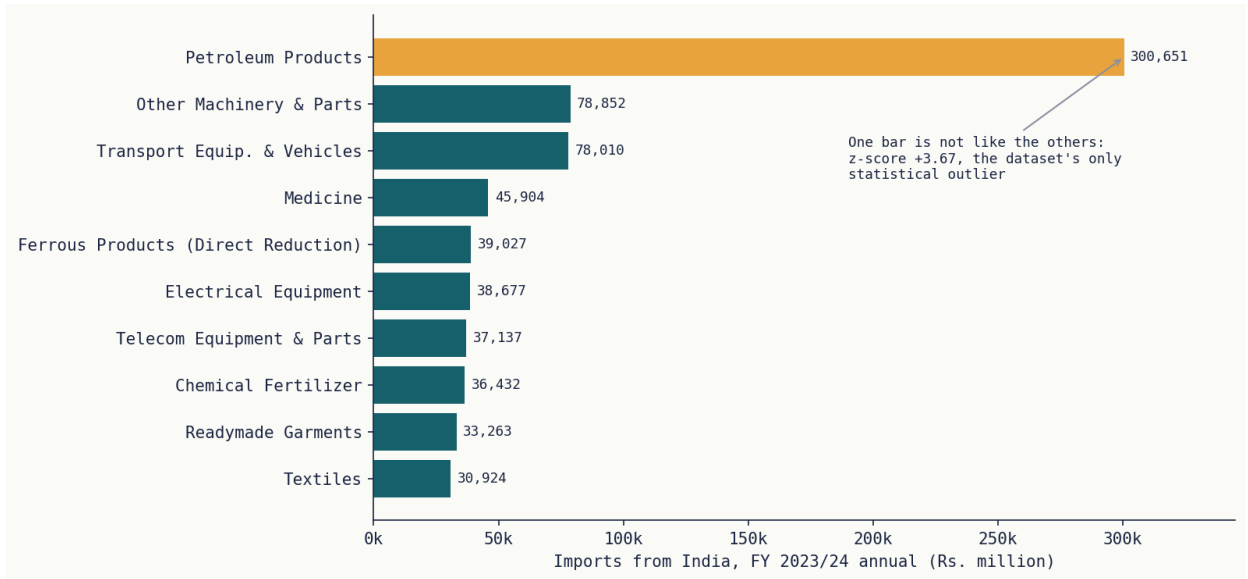


FIG. 01 – Top 10 imports from India, FY 2023/24 annual. Petroleum (marigold) is the dataset's only statistical outlier.

The statistics agree with the eye. Using the interquartile-range rule, any commodity above Rs. 59,289 million in the latest half-year counts as an outlier — and exactly one clears the fence: petroleum, at Rs. 134,406 million. Its z-score of +3.67 puts it more than three and a half standard deviations above the average commodity. In a dataset of twenty, that is not a big value; that is a structural fact about the economy.

ENTRY 2

The Average Import Doesn't Exist

Ask “what does a typical import commodity look like?” and the mean gives a misleading answer. In the latest six months the mean commodity was worth Rs. 28,929 million, but the median was only Rs. 19,959 million. The gap between the two, roughly Rs. 8,970 million, appears in every one of the five accounting periods, and it always points the same direction: **mean above median**, the signature of a right-skewed distribution.

A handful of giant line items drag the average far above the commodity in the middle of the ledger. The median, not the mean, describes the typical import.

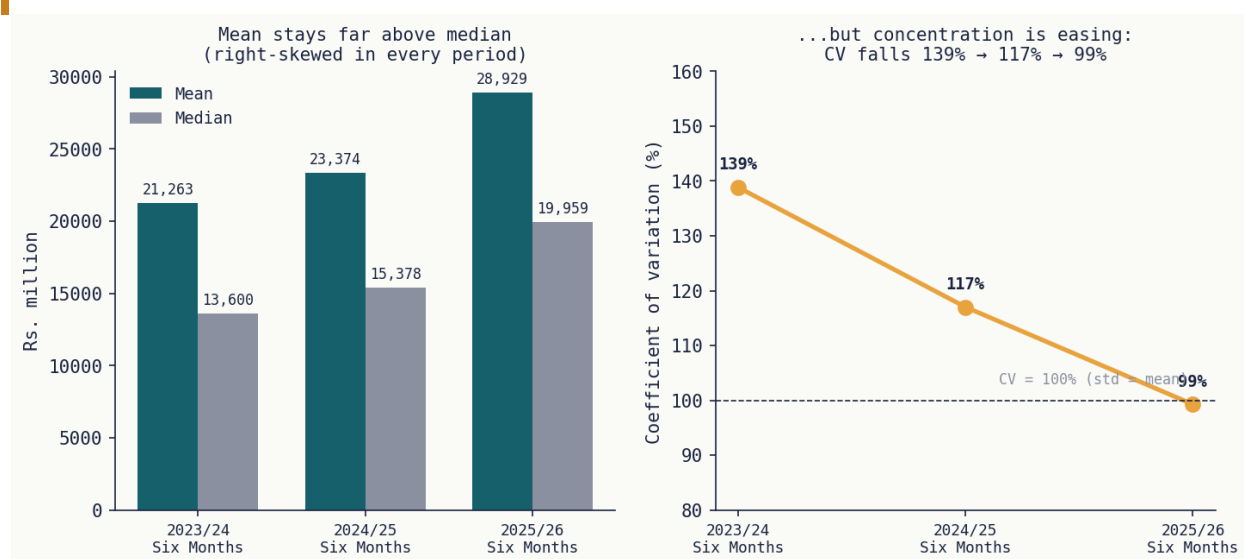


FIG. 02 — Left: mean vs. median, three six-month periods. Right: coefficient of variation (std ÷ mean) falling below the 100% line for the first time.

The right-hand panel holds the quieter, more interesting finding. The coefficient of variation — standard deviation as a share of the mean, a scale-free gauge of how unequal the basket is — has fallen steadily: 138.8% two years ago, 117.0% last year, 99.3% now. For the first time in this data the spread across commodities is smaller than the average itself. Petroleum still towers, but the rest of the basket is catching up: **Nepal's import mix from India is slowly becoming less concentrated.**

Silver Rush, Fertilizer Surge, Oil Retreat

Comparing the latest six months against the same window a year earlier, seventeen commodities with complete data split into three stories. The headline movers are precious metals: silver imports jumped +362% and gold +138% — a surge consistent with the record bullion prices of the past year pushing up the rupee value of every kilogram crossing the border. Chemical fertilizer (+156%) and crude soyabean oil (+134%) more than doubled as well, the latter feeding the refined-oil exports moving the other way across the same border.

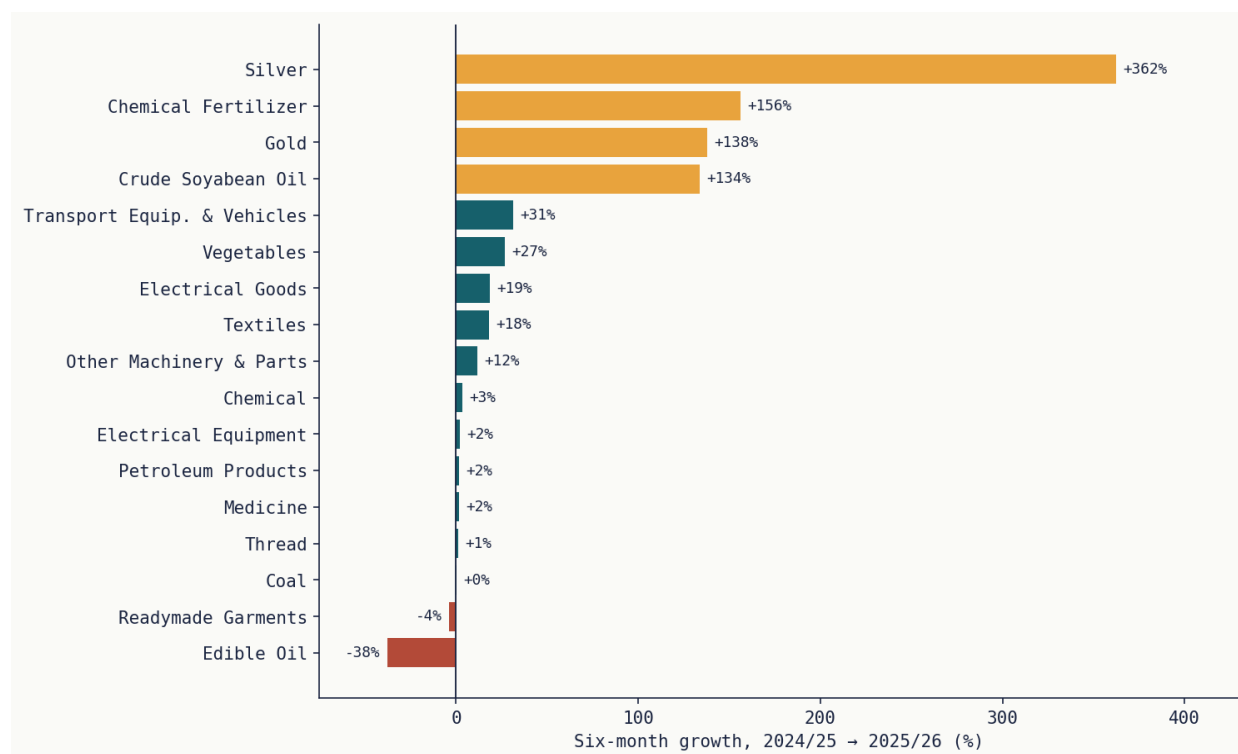


FIG. 03 — Six-month growth, 2024/25 → 2025/26. Marigold: more than doubled. Teal: grew. Brick: declined. Sub-Rs.3,000M commodities excluded.

At the other end sits edible oil, down -38% — the mirror image of the crude soyabean surge, as raw imports displace the finished product. Readymade garments slipped -4%. Everything else grew, which is itself worth noting: in a period when the total bill expanded, decline was the exception, not the rule.

The Steady Core of the Import Bill

Growth charts reward drama, so it is easy to miss the commodities that barely move — yet for planners and policymakers, these are arguably the most useful entries in the ledger. Measuring each commodity's coefficient of variation across all three six-month periods (this time across time for each row, not across commodities), a remarkably stable core emerges.

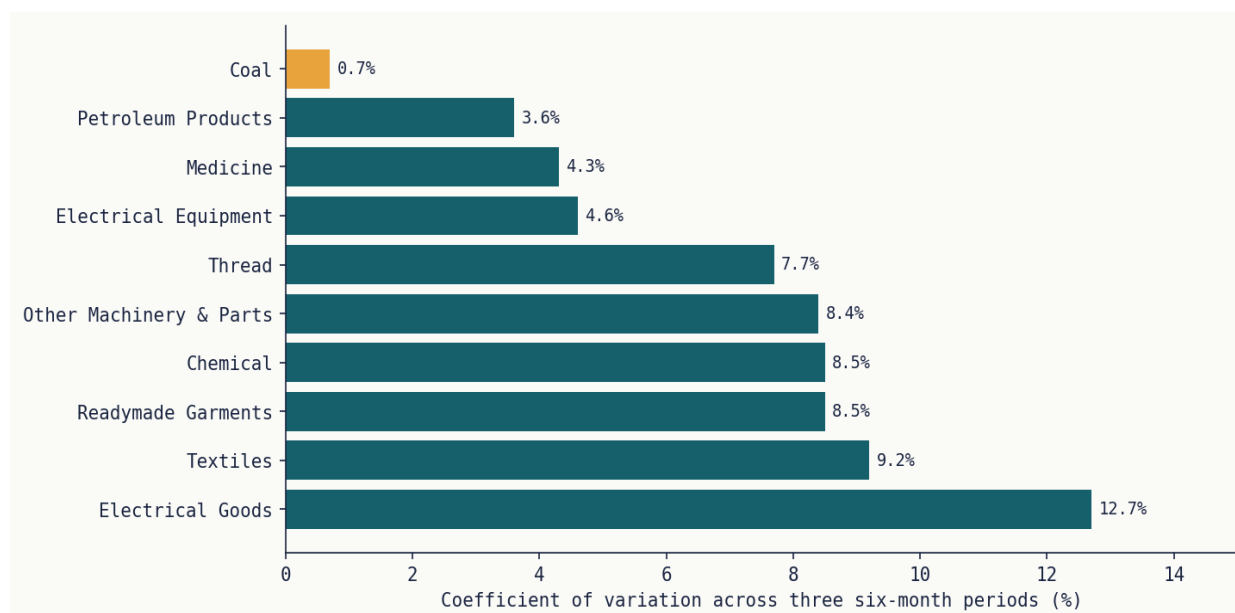


FIG. 04 – The ten steadiest imports, ranked by CV across the three six-month periods. Lower = more stable.

Coal is the ledger's metronome: Rs. 11,500 → 11,617 → 11,659 million across three periods, a coefficient of variation of just 0.7% — near-perfect constancy, the signature of steady industrial demand from cement and brick kilns. Petroleum, for all its enormous size, is the second-steadiest item at 3.6%: the biggest line in the ledger is also one of its most predictable. Medicine (4.3%) and electrical equipment (4.6%) round out a core of necessities that Nepal buys in almost identical quantities every half-year, regardless of what silver or soyabean are doing.

Size and volatility are different axes. The largest import is among the most stable; the fastest-growing is among the smallest.

What the Ledger Says, in One Paragraph

Nepal's import relationship with India is a heavily right-skewed distribution with a single structural outlier (petroleum), a fat middle of industrial and consumer necessities that scarcely moves (coal, medicine, machinery, textiles), and a volatile tail where the action happens (precious metals, fertilizer, edible oils). The concentration of the basket is genuinely easing — CV below 100% for the first time — driven not by petroleum shrinking but by the middle of the distribution growing. For anyone reading these tables, the practical lesson is statistical: report the median, not the mean; judge commodities by CV, not raw size; and treat any analysis that ignores the petroleum outlier with suspicion.

Source. Nepal Rastra Bank, Current Macroeconomic Situation, six-month data of FY 2082/83 — Table 18, “Imports of Major Commodities” (Rs. in million), covering 20 commodity groups across FY 2023/24, 2024/25 and the first six months of 2025/26

.Analysis & charts: pandas + matplotlib • Data: NRB six-month macroeconomic report, FY 2082/83 • All figures Rs. in million